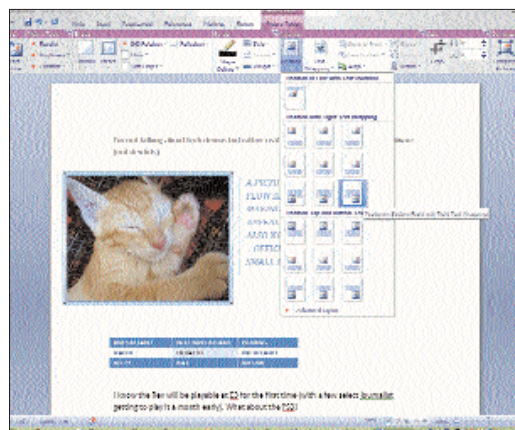


brightness or contrast, with the changes immediately visible on mouse hover.

Office 2007 also introduces the element of Contextual tabs. Insert a picture and then click on it to reveal a Picture Tools tab in the Ribbon, which allows you to add a shadow or 3D effects to the inserted picture. Insert a table to trigger a Table Tools tab—in the Ribbon, of course—which offers live formatting options. Notably, each of these Contextual tabs comes in its own identifiable colours, which is a great touch.

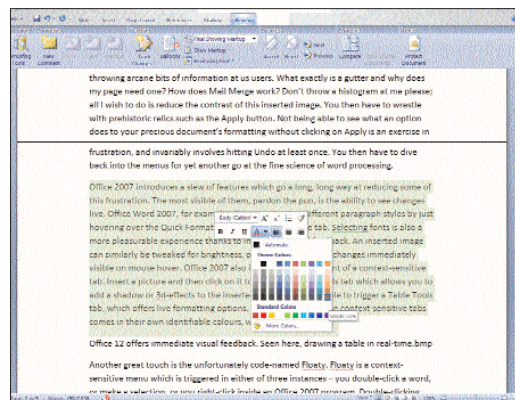


Contextual tabs such as Picture Tools in purple-pink here, are of great benefit to your current task

Another great touch is the Mini Toolbar. This is a context-sensitive menu triggered in any of three instances—you double-click a word, or make a selection, or you right-click inside an Office 2007 program. Double-clicking triggers a translucent Mini Toolbar that allows for quick format changes to fonts, bullets or alignment. The translucent window goes opaque when you bring your mouse cursor to it, and goes back to its ghost when the mouse moves away... it's an elegant and unobstructed path to frequently-used tools.

Right-clicking triggers an opaque Mini Toolbar attached to the regular right-click menu. Unfortunately, scrolling your list of fonts from within the Mini Toolbar does not reflect the choice live, thus diluting this feature. Perhaps the final version will incorporate this.

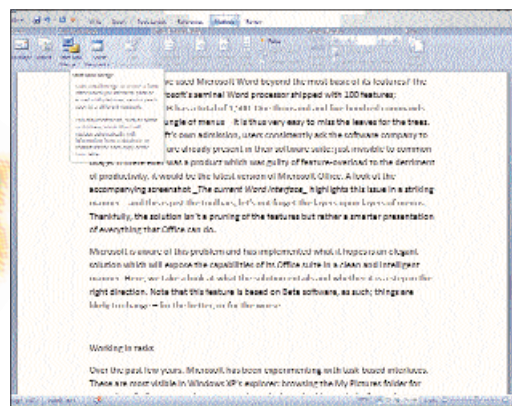
A problem with Mini Toolbars is that they are a bit intrusive. This is because it is triggered at random places within text, and we found



A Mini Toolbar triggered via a selection. Note the font tools offered

ourselves accidentally clicking it, especially while triggering it by making a selection. This can be solved by triggering the element a fixed distance away from the mouse cursor.

Another element that goes into making the suite's features more useful is enhanced ScreenTips. A ScreenTip appears when you move your pointer over an item in the Ribbon. Most often, we rely on hovering over a button to understand what it might do, rather than delve into the labyrinthine Help system. Recognising this, ScreenTips in Office 2007 are quite verbose, often detailing how a feature works; sometimes suggesting why it doesn't, while simultaneously displaying relevant shortcut keys, and a direct link to associated articles in the Help.



Office 12 offers detailed ScreenTips. This entry is practically a help file for Mail Merge

Yes, But... What's New?

Interface tweaks are nice, but does the beta offer a taste of any new features? Feature additions are minimal, at least those immediately visible. Behind-the-scenes changes aim to make the suite more appealing to today's connected workplace. The most important implementation, with this in view, is a new Office document format. Yes, Office 2007 adds another bevy of document formats to a world that has surely had enough. The new kids on the block are called the Microsoft Office Open XML Formats and are open, not as in open source, but open as in "use these or else..."

At least, they are royalty-free. Moreover, being based on the XML markup language, they do offer some neat treats. Data interoperability, for example: any third-party application can, in theory, create an Office XML document without the need to use Microsoft Office. The formats will add an X to the usual .doc and the .xls files of today, giving way to .docx, .xlsx, and so on. Such an XML document will practically be a ZIP container holding the actual document, alongside XML files and folders that define the content of the document, its formatting, embedded images, etc. It is a very modular approach to



A view of the Ribbon with the tabs. A new Tab called View seems to have been added